

Week 6 – Workshop

Magnetics: Anomalies and Susceptibility



Geophysics 3A: Potential Fields & Geothermics

July 24, 2026

Duration: 3 hours **Setting:** Workshop room (disc magnets, cube magnets, iron filings, susceptibility meter, ore and igneous rock suites)

Preparation

Pre-reading: Course Notes, Ch. 8

Lecture videos:

Notes:

Purpose

This workshop builds physical intuition for magnetic fields and their geological sources. Students first build up dipole field geometry from direct observation, then apply that intuition to predict anomaly shapes for idealised structures, before turning to what actually carries magnetisation in real rocks and how thermal structure limits it at depth.

Learning Outcomes

By the end of this workshop, students should be able to:

- Describe and predict magnetic field patterns generated by dipoles and combinations of sources
- Predict magnetic anomaly shapes from simple geological geometries, and contrast them with gravity anomalies for the same structures
- Relate magnetic susceptibility to rock type and geological process, and distinguish primary from secondary controls on it
- Explain the concept of Curie depth and its relationship to thermal structure
- Link source depth to anomaly wavelength and spectral content

Session Flow (240 min)

0–10 min: Warm-Up: Cutting a Magnet in Half

Thought experiment: if you cut a bar magnet exactly in half, does one piece become a pure “north” and the other a pure “south”?

- What do you predict happens to each half?
- If you kept cutting smaller and smaller pieces, would you ever reach a piece with only one pole?

Target idea: Every magnetic source, no matter how small, has both a north and south pole — an isolated magnetic pole has never been observed. Keep this in mind today: later in the session you’ll meet a case where a source’s field *looks* like it has only one pole. See if you can work out how that’s possible if isolated poles don’t exist.

10–45 min: Activity 6.A: Visualizing Magnetic Fields

- Iron filings with a single disc magnet, vertical and horizontal orientation
- Predict-observe-compare-reflect: two dipoles side by side
- A line of stacked magnets — field pattern near one end vs. along the side
- Optional extension: cube magnets, and whether shape alone can remove dipolar behaviour at range

45–60 min: Mini-Lecture: Naming What You Found

- Formalising vocabulary: dipole vs. monopole, why isolated magnetic poles cannot exist
- Dipole convergence figures: two opposite point poles at decreasing separation, showing how a monopole-like appearance at close range gives way to a dipole pattern at distance
- How magnetism differs from gravity (vector nature, polarity)
- Preview: applying this field geometry to predict anomalies from real geological structures

60–100 min: Activity 6.B: Magnetic Anomalies vs. Gravity

- Reasoning-based sketching of anomalies for idealised geometries (sphere, cylinder, slab)
- Direct comparison with gravity anomalies for the same bodies
- Vertical vs. horizontal inducing field

100–110 min: Break**110–120 min: Warm-Up: Which Property Matters Most?**

Suppose you could know only one property of every rock in the crust. Which would best help predict magnetic anomalies: FeO concentration, magnetite abundance, magnetic susceptibility, density, remanent magnetization, or oxidation state?

Target idea: There isn't a perfect answer — each property captures part of the picture but misses something else. Today's activity will show why susceptibility depends on a trace mineral phase rather than on any single bulk property.

120–165 min: Activity 6.C: Magnetic Susceptibility of Rocks

- Station 1: reaction pairs (peridotite/serpentinite, basalt/altered basalt, eclogite) — magnetite created or destroyed by reaction
- Station 2: igneous suite — magnetite set by primary crystallisation, no reaction involved
- Station 3: ore minerals — decoupling metal content from magnetism

165–215 min: Activity 6.D: Curie Depth and Magnetic Crust

- Curie temperature and magnetic crustal thickness
- Depth–wavelength relationships
- Antarctica case study
- Back-of-the-envelope heat-flow estimates

215–230 min: Wrap-up

- What magnetism can and cannot tell us
- Connection to upcoming Fourier/spectral methods

230–240 min: Preview: Fourier Transforms and Potential Fields

Both gravity and magnetic anomalies contain information about source depth encoded in their spatial wavelengths: deep sources produce broad, long-wavelength anomalies while shallow sources produce

narrow, short-wavelength anomalies. Next week we formalise this depth–wavelength relationship using Fourier transforms. We will see how gravity and magnetic data can be filtered, upward-continued, and reduced-to-the-pole in the wavenumber domain, and how sampling decisions control what geological features can be resolved.

Workshop Notes

Workshop Notes

Activity 6.A

Visualizing Magnetic Fields

Purpose

This activity develops physical intuition for magnetic fields as vector fields generated by dipoles. You will explore how field geometry depends on source orientation, on the interaction between multiple sources, and on how far you are from the source.

Learning Outcomes

By the end of this activity, you should be able to:

- Describe and sketch the field pattern of a single magnetic dipole in vertical and horizontal orientations.
- Predict and compare the field pattern produced by two interacting dipole sources.
- Identify how the field pattern near the end of a stacked line of magnets differs from the pattern along its side, and relate this to a finite geological structure.
- Explain why source orientation, not source strength alone, determines the shape of a magnetic anomaly.

Background

Iron filings align with the local field direction, so the pattern they form shows you field-line direction and curvature — where lines converge, diverge, and close. What filings do *not* give you is a reliable measure of field strength: filing density is too easily affected by how much you sprinkle and how the paper is tapped to treat as data. Throughout this activity, base your answers on field *shape and symmetry*, not on how densely the filings appear to cluster.

Materials

- Magnets
- Paper sheets
- Iron filings

Question 1. Single magnet — vertical orientation

Place a disc magnet flat on the table and sprinkle iron filings over a sheet of paper on top.

1. Describe the symmetry of the field pattern.
2. Where are the field gradients strongest?
3. If this magnet were buried at depth, where would you expect the strongest anomaly?



Sketch:

Question 2. Single magnet — horizontal orientation

Stand the same magnet on its edge and repeat the experiment.

1. How does the field symmetry differ from Part A?
2. Where are positive and negative lobes located?
3. How would this differ from a gravity anomaly produced by the same body?

Sketch:

Question 3. Two Dipoles Side by Side

Take two magnets magnets, oriented the same way (e.g. both vertical, both N up), and place them a short distance apart on the table.

Predict: Before sprinkling filings, sketch what you expect the combined field pattern to look like, based on what you saw for a single dipole in Part A.

Observe: Sprinkle the filings and sketch the actual pattern.

Question 4. Compare and Reflect:

1. Where does your prediction match the observed pattern, and where does it differ?
2. Is the field pattern in this activity ever simply the two single-dipole patterns added side by side with no distortion? Why or why not?

Question 5. A Line of Stacked Magnets

Stack several magnets with poles aligned (N up on every magnets) to form a short column, and repeat the iron-filings observation.

1. Examine the field pattern near one end of the stack. How does it compare to the single-magnet pattern from Part A?
2. Now examine the pattern along the side of the stack, away from either end. How is this pattern different from what you saw near the end?

Sketch both regions. You will return to this pattern later in the session — keep your sketch.

Question 6. Reflection

Why are magnetic field patterns sensitive to orientation, while gravity fields are not?

Key Ideas

Magnetic fields are dipolar, not monopolar. Every magnet has both a north and south pole; the field lines form closed loops. This gives magnetic anomalies a more complex shape than gravity anomalies, which arise from monopole-like mass distributions.

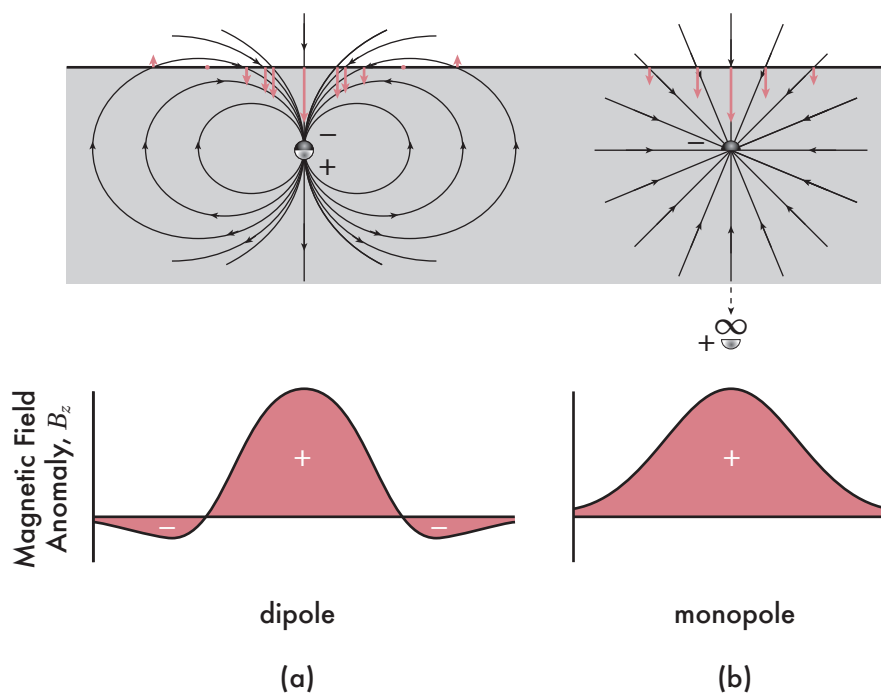


Figure 1: The (b) monopolar field of a point mass and the (a) dipolar field of a magnetic point source.

Orientation controls anomaly shape. Rotating the same source changes the pattern of positive and negative lobes without changing the source volume or susceptibility. This is the fundamental reason why magnetic interpretation requires knowledge of the inducing field direction and source magnetisation direction.

A line of aligned dipoles can look like a single pole — but only up close. Stacking magnets pole-to-pole cancels every internal north-south junction, leaving only the two outer poles, now separated by the full length of the stack. Close to one end, that far pole is negligible and the field looks like a single isolated pole. Far from the stack, both poles matter again and the field must revert to a two-lobed, dipolar pattern — because total magnetic charge is always exactly zero, no matter how a source is shaped or arranged. This is the same limit you tested with the cube magnet: no geometry escapes it, only postpones it to shorter range.

Activity 6.B

Magnetic Structures

Purpose

This activity mirrors previous gravity workshops. You will reason about magnetic anomaly shapes and compare them directly with gravity anomalies from the same structures.

Learning Outcomes

By the end of this activity, you should be able to:

- Sketch the expected vertical magnetic anomaly for a range of simple geological structures.
- Identify the sign, symmetry, width, location of steepest gradients, and asymptotic behavior for each structure.
- Compare magnetic and gravity anomalies for the same body and explain key differences in terms of the dipolar nature of magnetic fields.
- Explain why magnetic interpretation is more non-unique than gravity interpretation.

Assume:

- Uniform susceptibility
- Induced magnetisation only
- Constant inducing field

Background

Before sketching, it's worth anticipating one basic difference between gravity and magnetic fields from a compact source. Stripped down to the geometry alone — dropping mass, susceptibility, and other physical constants — the two fields scale with distance r from the source as

$$g \propto \frac{1}{r^2} \quad B \propto \frac{1}{r^3}.$$

A magnetic field falls off one power of r faster than the equivalent gravity field, because every magnetic source has both a positive and a negative pole rather than a single sign of mass. Practically, this means a magnetic anomaly from a compact, near-surface source should look *narrower and more sharply peaked* than a gravity anomaly from a source of the same size and depth. The same one-power-faster relationship holds for extended sources too, such as the cylinder and slabs below, even though the exact exponents shift with source geometry.

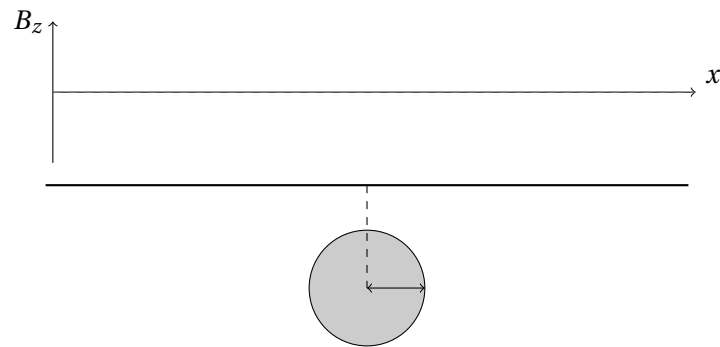
Instructions

For each structure:

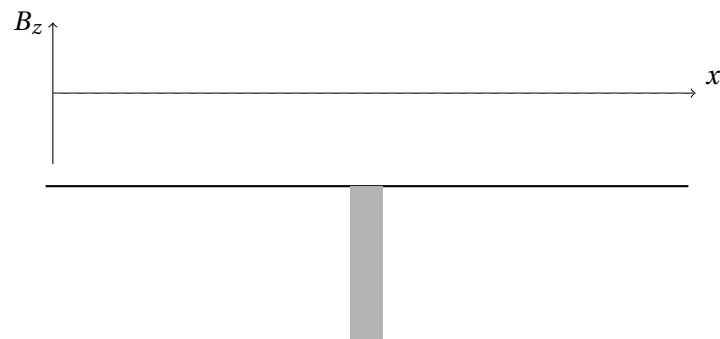
1. Sketch the expected vertical magnetic anomaly
2. Indicate sign, symmetry, width, and strongest gradients
3. State how it differs from the gravity anomaly

Structures

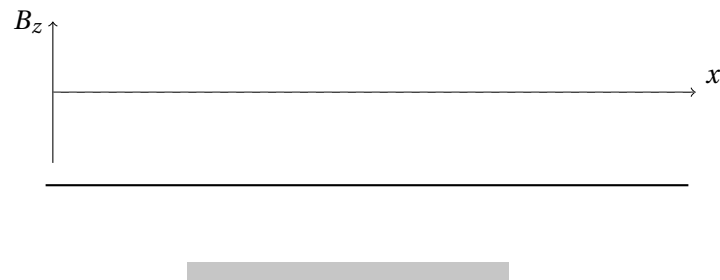
A) Buried Cylinder (2D; infinite strike)



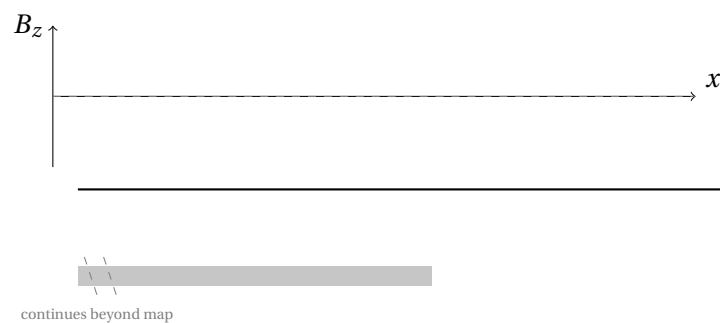
B) Vertical Slab



C) Finite-Extent Horizontal Slab



D) Semi-Infinite Horizontal Slab



Question 1. Vertical vs Horizontal Inducing Field

Repeat one case assuming a horizontal inducing field.

1. How does the anomaly shape change?

2. Which case appears more gravity-like?

3. Why does gravity not behave this way?

Question 2. Reflection

Give two reasons why magnetic interpretation is more non-unique than gravity.

Key Ideas

Sign and shape depend on source geometry and field direction, not just on source strength. A mass excess always produces a positive gravity anomaly, full stop. A susceptibility contrast produces a magnetic anomaly whose sign and shape depend on the body's geometry *and* on the direction of the inducing field — at the magnetic pole a symmetric body gives a symmetric, bipolar anomaly; at lower latitudes the same body gives an asymmetric one with shifted lobes. Gravity has no equivalent to either effect. (Recall the monopole/dipole comparison from Activity 6.A, Figure 1.)

Finite structures produce edge effects the end-member sketches don't show. Near the single edge of Structure D, the anomaly peaks just inside the edge and dips to a trough just outside it, then returns fully to zero further away — a point near the edge sits closer to source material on one side than the other, the same near-vs-far dipole reasoning behind the $1/r^3$ falloff above, just applied across an extended source. Structure C has *two* such edges. If they're far enough apart, each produces its own peak-and-trough and the interior settles to a shallow minimum rather than true zero; if they're close together, the two signatures can merge into something that looks more like a single smooth bump. Compare your sketches for C and D directly — can you tell which regime C is in?

Non-uniqueness is greater in magnetism than gravity. Three unknowns — susceptibility, geometry, and magnetisation direction — must all be constrained simultaneously. Remanent magnetisation (a frozen-in field direction different from today's) adds a fourth unknown. Additional constraints from geology, paleomagnetism, or other data are usually required to discriminate between models.

Activity 6.C

Magnetic Susceptibility of Rocks

Purpose

This activity links magnetic susceptibility to mineralogy and geological processes such as alteration, metamorphism, weathering, and igneous differentiation.

Learning Outcomes

By the end of this activity, you should be able to:

- Measure magnetic susceptibility on a range of rock and ore samples and record observations systematically.
- Relate susceptibility values to mineralogy, particularly the role of magnetite and other iron oxides.
- Distinguish primary (igneous) from secondary (alteration or metamorphic) controls on rock magnetic susceptibility.
- Discuss why susceptibility is not a simple proxy for bulk rock composition or metal content.

Background

Magnetic susceptibility (χ) describes how strongly a material becomes magnetised in response to a field:

$$\mathbf{M} = \chi \mathbf{H}.$$

Unlike density, which depends on the bulk mineralogy of a rock, susceptibility is controlled almost entirely by a trace phase. Magnetite's susceptibility is orders of magnitude higher than that of the silicate minerals that make up the bulk of most rocks, so even a few percent by volume of magnetite dominates the measured susceptibility regardless of what the rest of the rock is made of. A handful of Ni- and Co-bearing minerals can also contribute, but at typical crustal abundances their effect is negligible next to magnetite's.

Because susceptibility is set by a trace phase, it is sensitive to exactly which Fe-Ti oxide is present, not simply how much iron the rock contains. Figure 2 shows the relevant Fe-Ti oxide system: magnetite and its Ti-substituted relatives at one end, hematite and ilmenite at the other. Today's samples will let you see this system in action — the same starting rock can end up on either side of it, depending on what reaction it underwent.

Samples and Observations

Station 1: Reaction Pairs

Question 1. Reaction Pairs

1. Compare the peridotite and serpentinite susceptibility. How does serpentinisation lead to high magnetic susceptibility?

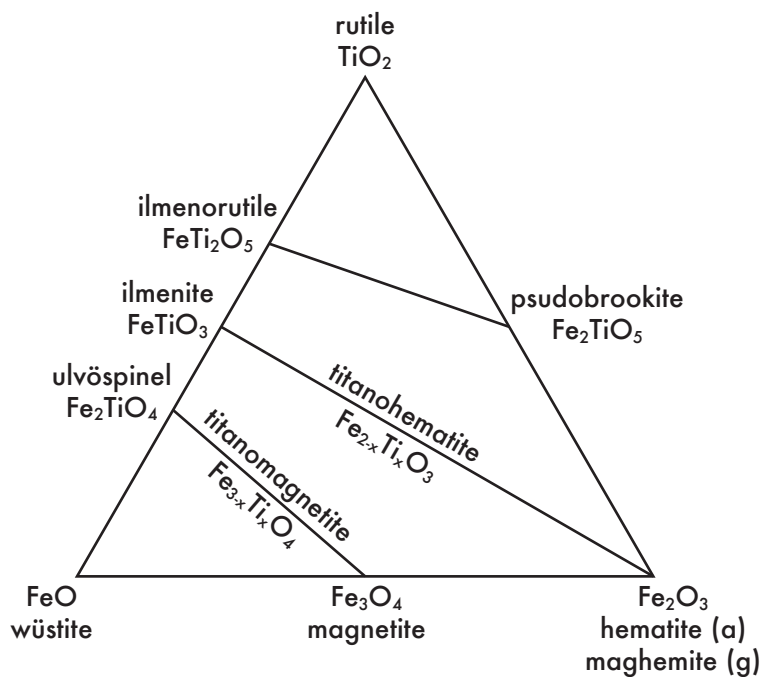


Figure 2: The Fe-Ti oxide system. Which side of this diagram a rock's oxide phase falls on — not its bulk iron content — determines whether it is magnetic.

Sample	Rock type	Geological context	Susceptibility (SI)	Notes
1	peridotite			
2	serpentinite			
3	basalt (fresh)			
4	basalt (altered)			
5	eclogite			

2. Compare the fresh basalt and altered seafloor basalt. Why can alteration dramatically reduce susceptibility in mafic rocks?

3. Compare the granite or sedimentary protolith with its metamorphosed equivalent. Which minerals control susceptibility in felsic or sedimentary rocks?

Question 2. Cross-Comparison: Two Paths to Low Susceptibility

Both the altered seafloor basalt and the eclogite are weakly magnetic, but they reached that state by different geological histories. Propose one observation (mineralogical, textural, or geochemical) that could distinguish which process — surface alteration or deep metamorphism — produced a given low-susceptibility sample.

Question 3. Cross-Comparison: One Process, Two Outcomes

Hydrothermal alteration acted on both the peridotite and the basalt in this activity, but with opposite magnetic consequences: serpentinisation of peridotite *produces* magnetite, while seawater alteration of basalt *destroys* it. Given that both are altered by broadly similar fluid-rock interaction, what property of the starting rock — rather than the process itself — determines whether magnetite is created or consumed?

Station 2: Igneous Suite

Sample	Rock type	Predicted rank	Susceptibility (SI)	Notes
6	gabbro			
7	diorite			
8	granodiorite			
9	granite 1			
10	granite 2			

Question 4. Igneous Suite

1. Before measuring, rank the igneous samples from most to least magnetic based on their appearance (color index, inferred mafic mineral content).

2. After measuring, compare your predicted ranking to the results. Does susceptibility track color index as expected? What might cause a sample to depart from the trend?

Station 3: Ore Minerals

Sample	Mineral	Predicted rank	Susceptibility (SI)	Notes
11	magnetite			
12	galena			
13	tin ore			

Question 5. Ore Minerals

1. Before measuring, rank the four ore samples from most to least magnetic, based on their appearance and metal content.

2. After measuring, compare your prediction to the results. Which sample most surprised you, and why?

3. Pyrite contains iron. Why is it only weakly magnetic, if at all, despite this?

Complete at the end

Question 6. Synthesis

1. Why is susceptibility not a simple proxy for bulk composition or metal content?

2. Which geological processes and settings tend to increase susceptibility, and which tend to decrease it?

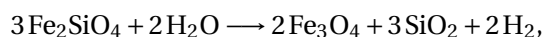
Question 7. Reflection

Explain why petrology is essential for interpreting magnetic anomalies.

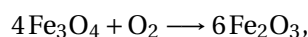
Key Ideas

Magnetite controls crustal magnetisation. Even small amounts of magnetite (a few percent by volume) dominate the magnetic susceptibility of a rock because its susceptibility is orders of magnitude higher than that of silicate minerals. Susceptibility is therefore highly sensitive to trace magnetite abundance, not bulk composition — and, as the ore station shows, not to metal content in general either.

Susceptibility depends on which Fe-Ti oxide is present, not how much iron the rock contains. Serpentinisation of olivine produces magnetite as a byproduct of hydration,



while oxidative weathering of basalt destroys magnetite by further oxidising it,



converting magnetite to hematite. Eclogitisation removes magnetite by a different route again — Fe and Ti are redistributed into garnet and omphacite as the rock recrystallises under high pressure, rather than through a single hydration or oxidation reaction.

The same process can have opposite magnetic outcomes. Neither “alteration” nor “metamorphism” has a fixed effect on susceptibility — each can create or destroy magnetite depending on the starting rock’s iron content and oxidation state, and the redox conditions of the fluid or melt involved. Predicting the outcome requires knowing the reaction geochemistry, not just naming the process.

Two very different histories can produce the same magnetic outcome. The altered basalt and the eclogite both end up weakly magnetic despite sharing a basaltic protolith — one lost its magnetite to near-surface oxidation, the other to deep metamorphic recrystallisation. A low susceptibility measurement alone cannot distinguish which history a sample experienced, foreshadowing the non-uniqueness problem you will meet again in Activity 6.C.

Igneous differentiation sets susceptibility before any alteration occurs. Progressively more felsic melts crystallise progressively less Fe-Ti oxide, so susceptibility can vary systematically across an igneous suite purely as a primary crystallisation effect, with no reaction or alteration involved at all.

Petrology is essential for magnetic interpretation. Without knowing the mineralogy and alteration history of the source rocks, it is impossible to distinguish between a mafic intrusion with high magnetite content and one that has been strongly altered. Both could produce very different magnetic anomalies despite similar bulk chemistry.

Activity 6.D

Curie Depth and Magnetic Crustal Thickness

Purpose

This activity explores how temperature limits crustal magnetisation and why deep magnetic structure is long-wavelength.

Learning Outcomes

By the end of this activity, you should be able to:

- Explain how the Curie temperature limits the depth of crustal magnetisation.
- Relate anomaly wavelength to source depth using the depth–wavelength principle.
- Compare seismic and magnetic estimates of crustal thickness and explain why they can differ.
- Estimate heat flow from Curie depth using a simple geothermal gradient.

Question 1. Curie Depth Concept

1. What mineral dominates crustal magnetisation?

2. What happens above the Curie temperature?

3. Is Curie depth a thermal or compositional boundary?

Question 2. Depth and Wavelength

Given several magnetic profiles:

1. Which correspond to shallow sources?

2. Which to deep Curie depth?

3. How does depth affect short wavelengths?

Question 3. Antarctica Case Study

Consider the magnetic and crustal structure of Antarctica (Fig. 3).

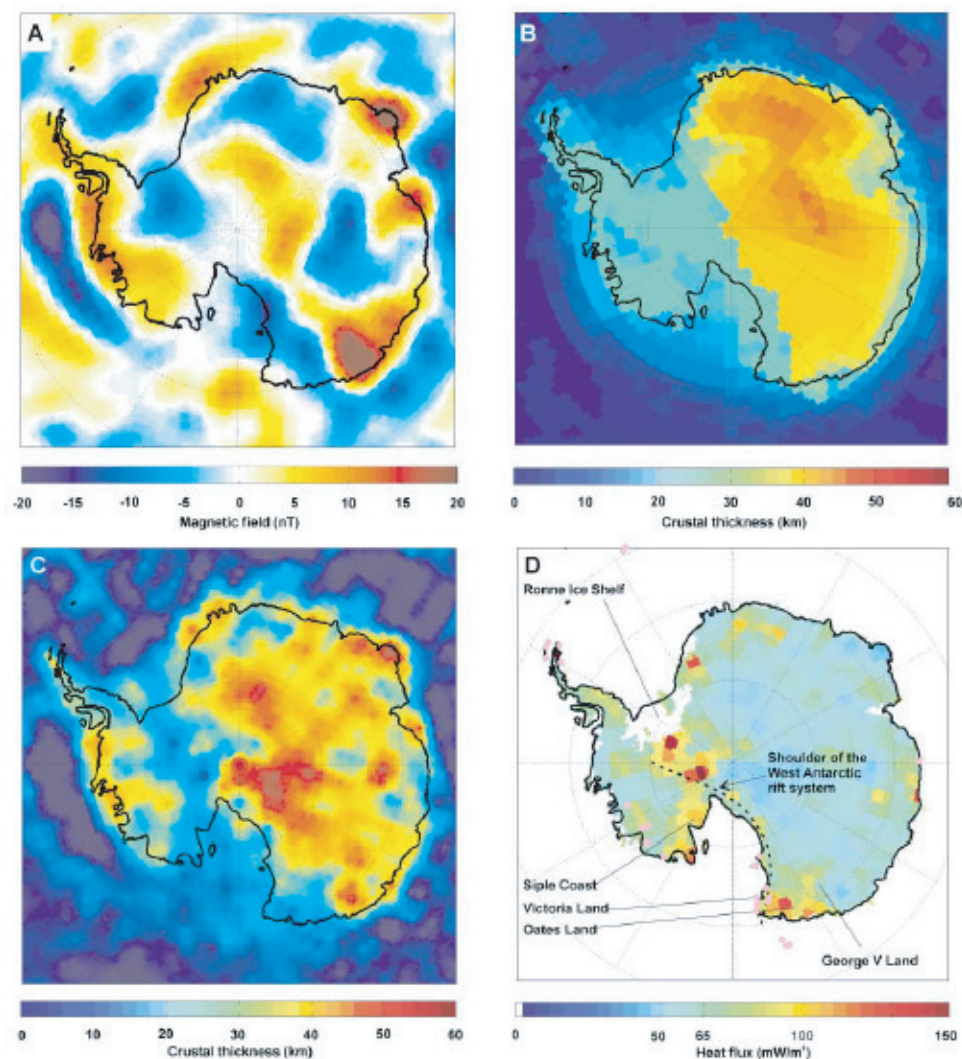


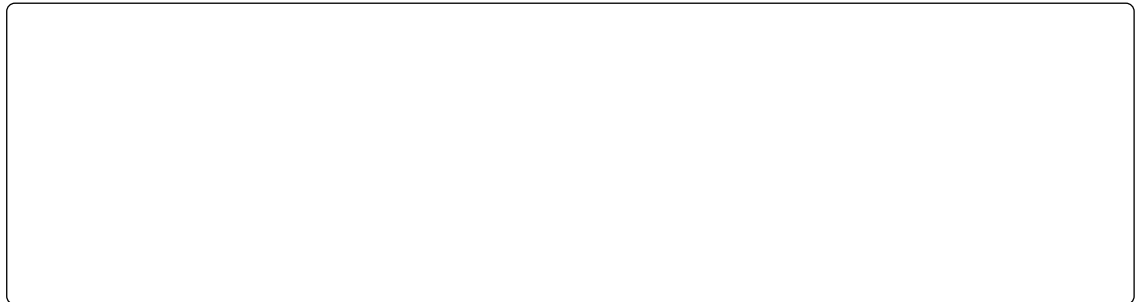
Figure 3: Estimating the Curie depth from vertical magnetic data. (a) Vertical magnetic field. (b) Crustal thickness model of Antarctica. (c) Estimate to base of magnetized layer. (d) Estimated heat flow. Figure from Maule et al. (**Science**, 2005).

Compare:

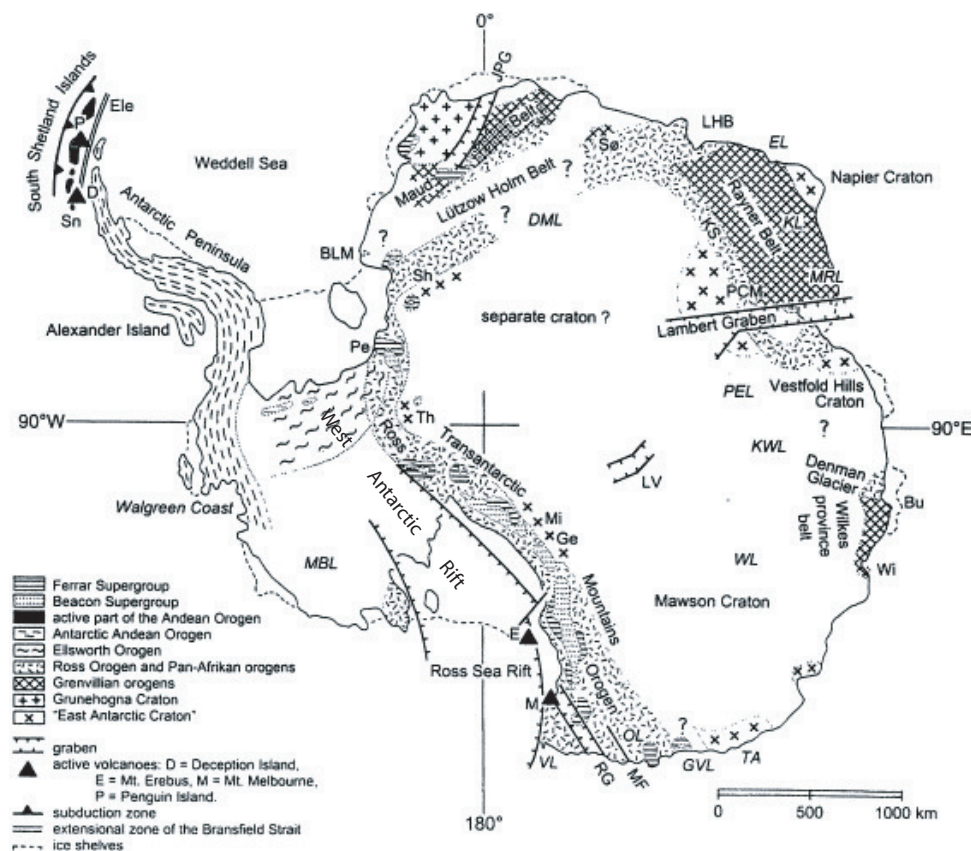
- Magnetic anomalies

- Seismic crustal thickness
- Magnetic crustal thickness

Why do seismic and magnetic thickness estimates differ?



The first-order geology of Antarctica is characterized by a stable (cratonic) region in East Antarctica and a Cenozoic rift in West Antarctica (Fig. 4).



Talarico and Kleinschmidt, in *Antarctic Climate Evolution*, 2008

Figure 4: Tectonic map of Antarctica from Talarico and Kleinschmidt (*Antarctic Climate Evolution*, 2008).

Question 4. Heat-Flow Estimate

The relationship below follows from Fourier's law of steady-state heat conduction, assuming a linear temperature increase from the surface to the Curie isotherm. We'll discuss this properly when we cover conductive heat flow in Week 8 — for now, take it as given and use it to estimate heat flow from the Curie depths you found in Part C.

Assume:

$$T_C = 570^\circ\text{C}, \quad k = 2.8 \text{ W m}^{-1} \text{ K}^{-1}$$

$$q = k \frac{T_s - T_C}{z}$$

where T_s is the surface temperature in $^\circ\text{C}$.

Estimate heat flow for a rift and a craton.

Question 5. Reflection

Explain why Curie depth makes magnetics sensitive to thermal structure.

Key Ideas

The Curie temperature defines the base of crustal magnetisation. Above this temperature (about 580°C for magnetite), thermal energy prevents the alignment of magnetic domains and the rock is effectively non-magnetic. The depth at which crustal temperatures reach the Curie point therefore sets the maximum depth from which magnetic anomalies can originate.

Curie depth is a thermal boundary, not a compositional one. Seismic Moho and magnetic Moho can differ substantially: a hot, thin crust (as in a rift zone) may have its Curie depth within the crust, whereas a cold, thick craton may have Curie depths that approach or exceed the Moho. This is why magnetic thickness and seismic crustal thickness differ systematically between tectonic settings.

Curie depth provides a heat-flow estimate. Assuming a linear geothermal gradient and a known Curie temperature, $q \approx kT_C/z_C$ gives a first-order heat-flow estimate. This is a powerful application because it provides continental-scale heat-flow maps where borehole measurements are unavailable (e.g., beneath Antarctic ice).

